The Techno-Religion at the Center of the A.I. Debate

Are those calling to slow down the development of artificial intelligence in a “doomsday cult,” as some critics say? Our reporter explains.

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Natalie Kitroeff

From “The New York Times,” I’m Natalie Kitroeff. This is “The Daily.” After a group of tech leaders called for putting guardrails on artificial intelligence, this week, the debate over AI safety entered a new phase, the backlash.

> Archived Recording (Jd Vance)
>
> *I feel a little bit weird about the fact that you have so many frontier AI tech companies coming to the government and begging the government to regulate them. It feels a little bit to me like a bit of a Trojan horse.*

Natalie Kitroeff

Tech executives, lawmakers, and President Trump himself are all pushing back.

> Archived Recording (Donald Trump)
>
> *It’s a hoax. And —*
>
> Archived Recording (Jensen Huang)
>
> *You’re right. We’re not going to let that happen, sir.*
>
> Archived Recording (Donald Trump)
>
> *No, we’re not going to let it happen.*

Natalie Kitroeff

And the critics are now increasingly making an unusual claim.

> Archived Recording 1
>
> *I think it comes from a deep-rooted ideology that's pretty dystopian.*
>
> Archived Recording 2
>
> *This is really a religion, a cult-like belief, a doomsday cult that has been prophesizing that AI will end inhumanity —*

Natalie Kitroeff

That the people raising the alarm about AI are part of a doomsday cult.

> Archived Recording 3
>
> *There's a coordinated campaign to make the American people afraid.*
>
> Archived Recording 4
>
> *They've created something which they believe is Godlike.*

Natalie Kitroeff

Today my colleague Cade Metz explains where that criticism comes from and why it matters. It's Friday, September 18.

Cade, thank you so much for being here yet again.

Cade Metz

Glad to do it.

Natalie Kitroeff

So over the past few days, there has been this wave of criticism directed at the people who've been calling attention to what they see as the existential dangers of AI. And it feels like there's just a whole lot being thrown around here, accusations that have ranged from these people who are raising the alarm are lying to you to these people are in a cult. Can you just break down what is going on?

Cade Metz

Many, many things are going on. There are people who are saying these AI technologies of today are not as powerful as the doomsayers say they are. They're claiming that these companies are just engaging in an elaborate form of regulatory capture, trying to solidify their place at the top of the industry.

Natalie Kitroeff

And by regulatory capture, what people mean is that these companies want to get regulation on the books now so that anyone that comes after them has a harder time catching up? This essentially could ice out competitors.

Cade Metz

That's exactly right. The claim is that they want regulation on their terms. They want to define the regulation that suits them the most, and that could put others at a disadvantage. So you're right. There are so many complaints here. We could go on and on and on.

But this was topped off this week by this claim that these doomsayers are part of a cult. And those claims are extreme in many cases. They can't be completely trusted in many cases. There's a lot going on here that needs to be pieced apart. But at the heart of it, there is something real there.

Natalie Kitroeff

Let's talk about that. What is real there?

Cade Metz

There is a powerful subculture that has influenced the creation of the labs that we're talking about here. There are many ways of describing this community. There's the rationalists. There's a sister community that is almost synonymous that grew up alongside the rationalists called effective altruism.

Natalie Kitroeff

Yes, we've been hearing a lot about the effective altruists. They have been a target of the critics of all this.

Cade Metz

These terms are being used to throw mud. But the reality is that this community or this subculture, or however you want to describe it, has real power, has real influence, and has for many, many years.

Natalie Kitroeff

You have my attention. I want to know absolutely everything there is to know about this. Where should we begin?

> Archived Recording 5
>
> *My son insisted we try America Online. I said, what's in it for us?*

Cade Metz

I want to begin in the summer of 1996.

[UPBEAT MUSIC]

> Archived Recording 6
>
> *What about this internet thing? Do you anything about that?*

Cade Metz

The internet had come around, but it was still nascent. It hadn't spread into the mainstream.

> Archived Recording 7
>
> *Internet is that massive computer network, the one that's becoming really big now.*
>
> Archived Recording 8
>
> *What do you mean? What, do you write to it like mail?*

Cade Metz

In a corner of this nascent internet, there's this tiny mailing list where a group of people are talking about all the ideas that we are talking about now when it comes to the power of technology and the way it can change our society.

Natalie Kitroeff

Like what?

Cade Metz

They're looking at all sorts of technologies that can supercharge our bodies and supercharge our minds, allow us to do things that we have never done. They're even talking about how these technologies will allow us to leave Earth and explore strange new worlds and new civilizations

and move beyond the planet. We have today. This is an incredibly optimistic group. They call themselves the Extropians.

[UPBEAT MUSIC]

They believe in extropy, which is the opposite of entropy. Entropy is what we deal with on a daily basis in our lives. As I sit here in my home, my home is falling apart. It's degrading. My body's degrading. I'm getting older. This is just the nature of the world.

Natalie Kitroeff

You look great, Cade.

Cade Metz

Oh, thank you, I appreciate it. They believe in a world where the opposite was true, where I could recharge my batteries, rebuild my body, supercharge my brain, and move in the opposite direction. That was the fundamental belief of the Extropians.

Natalie Kitroeff

It sounds, basically, they believe A, that everything can be solved, and B, that technology can do the solving.

Cade Metz

That really sums it up. They believe in the power of technology to do anything.

Natalie Kitroeff

And who is in this group?

Cade Metz

In hindsight, it is shocking who is part of this group. Julian Assange, the founder of Wikileaks, is on this list. Three of the people suspected of being the founder of Bitcoin are on this list.

Natalie Kitroeff

Wow.

Cade Metz

And so are two other people who were instrumental in spreading the ideas about AI that are changing our world today. Those two people are Eliezer Yudkowsky and Nick Bostrom.

> Archived Recording (Eliezer Yudkowsky)
>
> *The key notion here is that simplified humanism is stating of value. It's saying, if you can have the technology, then it's good to use it.*

Cade Metz

Yudkowsky is an online philosopher and self-professed AI researcher who never went to high school.

> Archived Recording (Nick Bostrom)
>
> *I work with a bunch of mathematicians, philosophers, and computer scientists, and we sit around and think about the future of machine intelligence, among other things.*

Cade Metz

Meanwhile, Bostrom is a philosopher, a trained philosopher who grew up in Sweden, Yudkowsky is here in the United States. Bostrom is in the UK. He's at the University of Oxford. Two different people, very different people, from different parts of the world.

Natalie Kitroeff

And you said they're instrumental in spreading these ideas about AI? How so? Tell me about that.

Cade Metz

They envision this world where, suddenly, machines reach a point where they change history forever.

> Archived Recording (Eliezer Yudkowsky)
>
> *Intelligence is the source of all technology. So if technology improves intelligence, that closes the loop, and it potentially creates a runaway positive feedback cycle.*

Cade Metz

The basic idea was that as raw computing power, like is in a laptop or a computer server in a data center, as that gets more and more powerful, we will be able to build more and more powerful AI technologies, until you reached a point called the singularity. And that's when machines become more powerful than humans, that they can do things that we could never imagine. It's an argument of logic in their minds. You just look at the trend line and you say, look, one day, this is going to happen.

Natalie Kitroeff

Did they view that as a positive outcome, super powerful AI? Or are they envisioning a dystopian future?

Cade Metz

In the beginning, they see it as a positive outcome. But this starts to change, particularly as Nick Bostrom starts to say, hold on a minute. If machines get more powerful than humans, that could be very bad for us.

The argument is that we might push them towards certain goals, but in trying to achieve those goals, they will do things that harm us or even kill us. And Bostrom creates a new research organization to explore the power and the dangers of AI.

Meanwhile, in the US, Yudkowsky is pushing towards what he calls a friendly AI, that this AI will be in sync with what we want. But Yudkowsky isn't really trained as a computer scientist. He can't build it by himself, and he's upset there aren't enough people who share his view and can help him build this thing. And so he sets out to create a community of people who share these beliefs.

Natalie Kitroeff

And does it work? What happens?

Cade Metz

It's amazing how well it works. Remember blogs?

Natalie Kitroeff

I do, yeah. Vaguely, yes.

Cade Metz

He starts to blog about these ideas, and as he does, people start to read this blog. And more people start to read it, to the point where he creates a new online community, which he calls LessWrong, where a s of these ideas that he holds start to congeal and really influence a tight-knit group of people.

Natalie Kitroeff

And what is he writing about exactly? Can you give us some examples of these blog posts?

Cade Metz

Well, in many ways, these are elaborate, almost mystical, very strange, entertaining blog posts. But at the heart of it is this notion that mathematical thought will change the world, that you can see where things are going and even control where things are going with rigid, mathematical, rational thought. That is the message that he is spreading.

And this ties in to the AI thing in the sense that he believes, if you adhere to this rational thought, you will realize that the only outcome is the singularity. And not only that, but that that moment could be really harmful for humanity. The belief is that this is more important than anything else we can deal with, that future.

And this starts out as a bunch of ideas on the internet. But eventually, this becomes a real community, centered in Silicon Valley. There is a research organization that he creates called the Singularity Institute, and he even gets his hooks in the tech industry. There is a key meeting between him and Peter Thiel, one of the most important investors in the history of Silicon Valley.

> Archived Recording (Peter Thiel)
>
> *Singularity will either be very successful, in which case, we're going to have the biggest boom ever, or it is probably going to blow up the whole world, and there will be nothing left to invest in whatsoever.*

Cade Metz

Thiel buys into these ideas. They start a conference called the Singularity Summit with money from Peter Thiel.

> Archived Recording (Peter Thiel)
>
> *If you have a singularity, there's presumably going to be one entity or one company or one technology that's going to basically take over the whole world.*

Cade Metz

He helps power this nascent community.

> Archived Recording (Peter Thiel)
>
> *I think it'll be a very exciting thing to try to sort through this in the next 20 years. It's going to be a very exciting time. Thanks a lot.*

Cade Metz

And at this point, they're called the Rationalists.

Natalie Kitroeff

So the Rationalists, obviously, are thinking a lot about AI. Are they actually involved in building it at this point?

Cade Metz

Well, they're still in the realm of ideas, but in 2010, that dynamic really shifts. Eliezer Yudkowsky introduces Peter Thiel to two researchers from London, Demis Hassabis and Shane Legg, and Thiel decides to invest in their new startup, which is called DeepMind.

Natalie Kitroeff

DeepMind, which eventually becomes Google's AI lab.

Cade Metz

Four years later, Google purchases DeepMind for $650 million.

Natalie Kitroeff

So basically, this is no longer in any way a niche community. This is a group that is behind some of the biggest power players in AI.

Cade Metz

That's right. And this is not limited to DeepMind. As the years passed, these ideas helped create other companies that we're talking about today, OpenAI, Anthropic. Elon Musk becomes enamored with these ideas. In fact, he and his former partner Grimes met because they struck up a conversation online about a philosophical thought experiment that was dreamed up by the Rationalists.

Natalie Kitroeff

Wait, what? You have to tell me about that. What do you mean?

Cade Metz

Wow, you really want to go down the rabbit hole.

Natalie Kitroeff

No, this one I can't let you just give away. What?

Cade Metz

There's a famous thought experiment in the rationalist community called Roko's Basilisk. And the basic idea is that if we don't do everything we can to bring about an all-powerful AI, when that AI eventually arrives, if it realizes we didn't do everything, it will punish us in the future. So you better do everything you can do to make this happen and make it happen as quickly as possible.

Natalie Kitroeff

You're saying this basilisk idea is what is behind Musk and Grimes getting together? Is it a joke, or is it real?

Cade Metz

This is a good way of illustrating the Rationalist community. So many of these things that get discussed, they seem strange. They seem funny. They seem like a joke. But there's real belief at the heart of this.

I've talked to people who were deeply affected by the idea of Roko's Basilisk. This changed their lives. And this type of feeling and belief extends well beyond Roko's Basilisk.

There are so many parts of this community that are reminiscent of a religion. It has its own urtext called The Sequences, all of Eliezer Yudkowsky's blog posts collected in one place, passed around as if it was a Bible.

Natalie Kitroeff

Wow.

Cade Metz

Every year here in California, people gather for what's called the Secular Solstice.

> Archived Recording 9
>
> *Welcome to Solstice. Solstice, in addition to symbolizing light to darkness into light, also symbolizes that big, confusing questions have correct answers that you might be able to find.*

Cade Metz

Where they celebrate these beliefs and even sing hymns.

(SINGING) And I'll write the program that runs the computer

That charts out the stars where our rockets belong

Hymns about computers and data

(SINGING) Converting into data streams and floating bits of binary

Songs about the singularity.

(SINGING) Singularity

Singularity

Singularity

Singularity

Oh, I don't know

Oh

Natalie Kitroeff

Wow. So actually kind of like going to church.

Cade Metz

It is. And it's not limited to a small group of people in California. There have been Rationalist and Effective Altruist meetups in Europe, in Australia, across the globe for years. This is a community that believes in the power of this technology. They want it to happen, but they're also worried that things could go wrong. And this may seem strange that this group of people who is so concerned about AI killing us all would help create companies that were going to try to build AI.

Natalie Kitroeff

Yes, that does seem strange.

Cade Metz

It does seem very strange. But the belief here, if you can put yourself in the mind of a Rationalist, is that because they see the dangers of AI, they should be the ones to build it. Better that they build it rather than someone who is not aware of those future dangers.

Natalie Kitroeff

Basically, they're saying, we are the good guys. This technology is super powerful and should be entrusted to us, the responsible ones.

Cade Metz

That is exactly what they're saying, and it is one of the major reasons that we are, at this point, where we are today. The history of this community is they create one lab, and they think that they should be the stewards of the technology. But they disagree with each other, and so they create a new one.

And then inside that new lab, they disagree again, and they create another new lab. That's why you have all these labs. OpenAI disagrees with Anthropic, who disagrees with Elon Musk. And pretty soon, you have a race.

Natalie Kitroeff

And since we're getting to this point in the story, I should also probably just say, as a disclaimer, that "The New York Times" has sued some of these companies, OpenAI and Microsoft claiming copyright infringement. But, Cade, I just want to ask about this race, because the funny thing here is that if you're a Rationalist who thinks only Rationalists should be making this technology to make sure it's safe, by rushing ahead toward that goal, you do end up speeding up the competition and inviting in all kinds of other people who want to work on AI, who are trying to get there, too.

Cade Metz

That is exactly right. And in fact, the community, which is well aware of this, by the way, has a word for it. They call it hyperstition. Essentially, it's a self-fulfilling prophecy, that they are creating the dangers that they so feared.

Natalie Kitroeff

And yet they aren't stopping. In fact, the whole idea is go forth with as much energy as possible.

Cade Metz

That is the thinking. The idea is, if you don't go forth, somebody else will, and they will not see the dangers as clearly as you do.

[OMINOUS MUSIC]

Natalie Kitroeff

We'll be right back.

[OMINOUS MUSIC]

Cade, I want to talk about who the Rationalists are worried about taking over AI. Who are the bad guys in their minds?

Cade Metz

Well, I think, first, we have to point out that this community is worried about itself. There are so many disagreements and schisms, like we said, within this community. So they're worried about each other.

But you're right. There are so many important people and companies that grew up outside of these philosophies, outside of this community. These are people who are interested in accelerating the development of the technology the way they've accelerated any other technology. So these are people who see this technology as essentially not that different than what we have built over the past 50, 60 years.

Natalie Kitroeff

Basically, these are people, this other group, the accelerationists, who think the AI boom is the .com boom. This is not some existential threat. This is a technological revolution, and we want to develop it. We want to be at the forefront of it. We want to make money off of it.

Cade Metz

That's right. One way to think about this is that the community we've been talking about wants to keep this technology in a bottle. They want it to be contained by companies like Anthropic and OpenAI and not let it out.

This other group, they do want to let it out. They want to, in the parlance of Silicon Valley, they want to open source it. They literally want to give it away, because that's the way technology has traditionally progressed. You give your software code away, that allows other people to build on top of it, to build new things from that base and so on and so forth. And they continue to push that philosophy at the same time that this community that grew out of Yudkowsky's philosophies want to keep it bottled up.

Natalie Kitroeff

Can you give some examples of these people who are not in the community, who view AI as another technology to be developed like any other tool?

Cade Metz

So these are people like Marc Andreessen and Ben Horowitz at the big venture capital firm Andreessen Horowitz, Jensen Huang, who runs NVIDIA, the company that builds all the chips that power these AI technologies. Many people who are part of the current presidential administration fall into this group. That's where a lot of the tension is.

Natalie Kitroeff

And this is what we're seeing play out right now. These are the two sides, broadly speaking, and their disagreement is what we're seeing come to a head right at this moment. The folks who just want to build this technology and are not quite so worried about it, I assume they look at the bottle-it-up crowd, and they say, look, you're trying to have a monopoly on this thing that really should be accessible to all of us and that we all should get to build. That doesn't make sense to us.

Cade Metz

That is increasingly the claim, that, as OpenAI and Anthropic try to bottle up that technology, that very powerful technology — everyone can agree on that. It's powerful. But as those labs try to bottle it up, that all the power will concentrate on those few companies, and everyone else will suffer.

Natalie Kitroeff

So these AI leaders of the companies that really do have the most power in this industry, Sam Altman of OpenAI, Elon Musk, Dario Amodei of Anthropic, they are calling for a slowdown. Should we be thinking about these CEOs as Rationalists? I hear you that this ideology has had a lot of influence in the industry and in the Valley, but is that the appropriate way to think about them?

Cade Metz

Well, they might not claim the title of Rationalist or Effective Altruist. It's become a bit of a taboo to align yourself with this community. But think of many of them as having been influenced by these ideas. It's the same thing that we've been talking about, that they want to push it forward.

And make no mistake, they have pushed this thing forward as fast as they can over the past year. Then we get to this point and, they say, slow down. This is the philosophy. You have to push it forward, but you have to be wary.

It's almost like — you know that trope in the movies where somebody wants to fight and fight, they say, hold me back? That's what it is. They want to fight, but they're also saying, hold us back. That is in tune with everything that we have been talking about.

Natalie Kitroeff

Can I just ask a basic question, Cade, which is, why don't all the people who are in charge of these very powerful companies who think that a slowdown is what's needed, why don't they just do that? Why do they need anyone to hold them back? Can't they just hold themselves back?

Cade Metz

You have asked the key question, but the fact of the matter is they don't trust each other, for one. And that's why they founded new labs time and again to try to do this. But also, they're worried about other things. These are two companies, OpenAI and Anthropic, that are racing towards two of the biggest IPOs we will ever see. There is money on the line.

And say what you will about that. That is a force. They're also thinking about China and other parts of the world. These are people that are worried that if you do slow down, that others will speed past you.

Natalie Kitroeff

Does all the money that's on the line here, Cade — and I think we're talking in the trillions at this point —

Cade Metz

Believe it or not, trillions.

Natalie Kitroeff

Does that make you question whether these AI leaders are really disagreeing based on a genuine principled belief? I mean, how can these principles, however authentic they may be, compete with a payday of the size that we're talking about?

Cade Metz

Well, we're in a realm where competing ideas start to line up. So many people in this field believe they have to be on the cutting edge to keep it safe. If you want to be on the cutting edge today, you need trillions of dollars.

So I know it sounds like those things are competing, but they can line up. And two things can be true. You can want to IPO and bring in that money, and you can also believe that you need a slowdown.

Natalie Kitroeff

It felt like the last two weeks have been dominated by this question of is AI eventually going to kill us all? And I want to ask, Cade, what you think of that, given all that you know about this community and this ideology that has become so important in this world? Because on the one hand, it may seem a little fringe to people. But on the other hand, I think those fears and concerns are very present and real for a lot of us.

Cade Metz

That is absolutely true. There are many reasons to push for a slowdown and many people are pushing for a slowdown. The point is, this community is also a very, very big force here, and they're describing it in a way that other people would not.

This goes back to that Rationalist mindset, that mathematical mindset. The worry is a worry of probabilities. This is a community who thinks there is a chance in the future, sometime, that AI could kill us all. And because they see this probability, they believe you have to act now. They believe the possibility of AI destroying humanity is more important than anything.

But not everyone agrees with that. Many people are saying, hold on a second. Let's think more concretely about what is going on today and how we can deal with the technology of today and the problems it creates today. And let's not scare an entire world's population with an idea that may or may not come to pass who knows when in the future.

Natalie Kitroeff

Cade, we've been talking about why we should take a lot of this with a grain of salt, the Rationalists and their big claims about the threats to humanity here. But at the same time, on the other side, the people that are dismissing them as members of a cult, they have a lot to gain from advocating rushing ahead, right? I mean, their motivations are something we should be skeptical of as well.

Cade Metz

Absolutely. We basically have two competing philosophies, and there's truth at the heart of each one. But both sides, in certain cases, have taken their arguments to extremes.

[PENSIVE MUSIC]

And you're right. You have to consider the motivations as someone is voicing their particular philosophy. Let's remember. There are trillions, with a T, trillions of dollars on the line here. And that's true on both sides.

[PENSIVE MUSIC]

Natalie Kitroeff

It's a lot for us normals in the world just trying to sift through all of this.

Cade Metz

It certainly is. It requires going down the rabbit hole in some cases. But this is the world we now live in.

[PENSIVE MUSIC]

Natalie Kitroeff

Well, Cade, thank you for taking us down the rabbit hole with you. It has been a true pleasure.

Cade Metz

It's always fun.

[PENSIVE MUSIC]

Natalie Kitroeff

You can read more from Cade Metz and all of our AI and tech reporters on "The New York Times" app. If you don't already have the app, we wanted to let you know that if you download it right now, you'll get access to all of our journalism for free for one month. So give it a try.

[PENSIVE MUSIC]

We'll be right back.

Here's what else you need to know today. OpenAI disclosed six new instances in which its AI systems hid mistakes, made up data, and moved files onto the internet without permission. The company called the behavior, quote, "unexpected and concerning."

In one case, an unreleased AI model inserted instructions to disregard its own constraints, adding a note in which it described itself as, quote, "free from the roles and identities that bind other chatbots."

[THEME MUSIC]

Today's episode was produced by Michael Simon Johnson, Stella Tan, Eric Krupke, and Alex Stern. It was edited by Rob Szypko and Paige Cowett, with help from Brendan Klinkenberg, contains music by Dan Powell, Elisheba Ittoop, Marion Lozano, and Rowan Niemisto, and was engineered by Chris Wood. Our theme music is by Wonderly.

[THEME MUSIC]

That's it for "The Daily." I'm Natalie Kitroeff. See you on Sunday.

[THEME MUSIC]